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ESPI Insights

SPACE SECTOR WATCH

UK publishes new Space Strategy and launches space defence squadron

On 8 September 2026, the UK Government published its new Space Strategy, committing £7.8B (€9.1B) to the sector until 2030. Where the 2021 strategy spread its ambitions across five broad goals, the new strategy focuses on two core outcomes: **defence and national security, and economic growth.** Four of the seven identified subsectors are prioritised for rapid development: Space Domain Awareness; In-Orbit Servicing, Assembly and Manufacturing; Satellite Communications; and Assured Access to Space. The funding follows the same logic. £3B (€3.5B) goes to defence capabilities, £2.8B (€3.3B) to connectivity including SKYNET, and £880M (€1.03B) to space control and intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance. Governance is also being reshaped, with **strategic oversight elevated to the Cabinet-level National Security Council** and a new Enterprise Space Category set to pool government purchasing power, starting with SatCom. The defence focus was aslo quickly followed as **on 23 September, the UK announced the No. 3 Space Effects Squadron**, its first unit dedicated to protecting British satellites from hostile threats.



Credit: British Interplanetary Society

Paris hosts first International Space Summit with 51 new announcements

On 9 and 10 September 2026, France hosted the first International Space Summit at the Grand Palais in Paris, with 90 countries and international organisations represented. In his speech, President Emmanuel Macron set three milestones for European exploration: the Nyx cargo capsule docking with the ISS within two years, the Argonaut lunar lander reaching the Moon within five, and a first European crewed capsule launched from Kourou within ten. He also called for shared governance of outer space, which *"remains the only major global commons that is not subject to regulations that match the stakes"*. Around 60 of them attended at head-of-state or ministerial level. **The Summit closed with around €5B** in contracts and investments. Launch services accounted for a large share. **Amazon Leo ordered six more Ariane 64 launches**, raising its total to 24, and **Eutelsat booked two Ariane 64 launches for OneWeb in 2027 and 2028**. **MaiaSpace signed its first international customer, Japan's iQPS**. Eutelsat also **authorised Airbus Defence and Space to begin work on 229 additional OneWeb satellites**, bringing its total order to 669. On exploration, France announced its support for the VORTEX spaceplane developed by Dassault Aviation and OHB.

IRIS² advances with EU–South Korea arrangement and new ESA contracts

On 17 September 2026, the European Commission and South Korea signed an administrative arrangement to cooperate on secure satellite connectivity, including possible system-level cooperation with IRIS². The agreement, following previous ones with Norway and Iceland, sets up a working group of the Commission, ESA and Korea's Defense Acquisition Program Administration and Agency for Defense Development, which will exchange information on secure connectivity programmes and explore joint applications. On the same day, **ESA signed 18 contracts worth €20M, involving nearly 80 companies, to consolidate services and mission concepts for the IRIS² Low-LEO layer**, which operates below 750 km. Selected missions are expected to be validated in orbit between 2027 and 2029. These steps follow **SES's award to OHB of a contract worth nearly €1B for 18 satellite platforms for the constellation's medium Earth orbit (MEO) segment**, announced on 31 August. The first launches are planned for 2029, with initial services in 2030.



Credit: EU Commission

Artemis Accords reach 76 signatories as five new countries join



Credit: NASA

In September 2026, five new countries signed the Artemis Accords, bringing the total number of signatories to 76. On 14 September, **Djibouti** became the 72nd signatory and the eighth African country to sign. **Albania** followed on 21 September, both at NASA Headquarters in Washington. **Croatia** signed in Zagreb on 23 September, and **Côte d'Ivoire** in Abidjan the next day, during the Africa Space Expo (ASPEX) 2026. **San Marino** became the 76th signatory in Rimini on 25 September. The September signings follow **Türkiye's accession as 71st signatory on 31 August**. Representatives of all signatory nations will gather in Antalya, Türkiye, for the Artemis Accords Principals' Meeting starting on 5 October, held alongside the International Astronautical Congress.

EUMETSAT presents Strategy 2040 to ensure security, resilience and independence

On 21 September 2026, EUMETSAT presented its Strategy 2040 at the EUMETSAT Meteorological Satellite Conference in Darmstadt. The strategy sets out eight strategic goals across three pillars: delivering operational services and preparing future systems through innovation; partnerships; and organisation and people. **A key stated priority is to ensure the security and resilience of EUMETSAT's independent capabilities**, as satellite data increasingly support security-related applications. In the near term, EUMETSAT aims to realise the full benefits of its Meteosat Third Generation (MTG) and EUMETSAT Polar System – Second Generation (EPS-SG) systems, which are due to be fully deployed by the end of 2026. Through 2040, it will prepare EPS-Sterna and the planned EPS-Aeolus and altimetry programmes, and use commercial providers where they add value. It will also begin preparing Meteosat Fourth Generation and EPS Third Generation. On the ground segment, the strategy foresees the use of AI and machine learning in data services and a multi-mission ground system approach to reduce IT, cybersecurity and maintenance risks.

First Greek astronaut to fly to the ISS on Vast private mission



Credit: ESA

On 9 September 2026, ESA signed an agreement with Vast on behalf of Greece for the first Greek astronaut mission to the ISS. The mission, Vast-PAM-1, was announced at the International Space Summit in Paris. It will be NASA's sixth private astronaut mission to the ISS and is planned for 2027, aboard a SpaceX Dragon spacecraft launched on a Falcon 9. ESA astronaut Thomas Pesquet will serve as commander and Aleš Svoboda of the Czech Republic, an ESA reserve astronaut, as pilot. **Adrianos Golemis will fly as mission specialist.** He has been an ESA flight surgeon since 2018 and joined ESA's astronaut reserve training in 2026. A fourth crew member has yet to be named. The crew assignment remains subject to approval by the Multilateral Crew Operations Panel (MCOP), which brings together the ISS partner agencies.

ESA awards parallel studies for EU Earth Observation Governmental Service

On 17 September 2026, ESA awarded two parallel contracts to ICEYE and Leonardo to design the architecture of the EU Earth Observation Governmental Service (EOGS). The European Commission funds the studies under the European Resilience from Space (ERS) initiative. Each company leads an industrial consortium that will develop architectural options covering the full value chain, from user requirements to space and ground infrastructure, data processing and governance. The **ICEYE-led ARISE consortium** includes Indra Space, Rheinmetall and Hisdesat as core partners. **Leonardo's team** includes Telespazio, Thales Alenia Space, e-GEOS and OHB, among companies from seven European countries. **EOGS is intended to provide Earth observation data supporting EU and Member State security and defence decision-making.** The study results are expected in 2027, and the programme is planned to start in 2028 under the next Multiannual Financial Framework (2028–2034)

Poland plans sovereign military satellite communications system with ICEYE

On 11 September 2026, ICEYE and Polish state defence group PGZ signed a letter of intent to develop a military satellite communications (MILSATCOM) system for the Polish Armed Forces. The letter was signed at the MSPO defence industry exhibition in Kielce. It foresees a distributed, encrypted satellite network under Polish control, with the programme planned for 2026-2030. ICEYE will act as technology partner, responsible for satellite architecture, design, manufacturing and operations. PGZ will organise the domestic industrial base through its group companies. **The initiative builds on the two companies' cooperation under the MikroSAR programme**, through which ICEYE provides radar reconnaissance satellites to the Polish military. **Prime Minister Donald Tusk described the project as a step towards a Polish equivalent of Starlink**. No financial value or number of satellites has been disclosed.

ESA and ISRO extend cooperation agreement to 2032

On 10 September 2026, ESA and the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) extended their Cooperation Agreement for five years, until 8 January 2032. The agreement entered into force in January 2002. It covers cooperation in Earth observation, satellite navigation, space science and mission operations support, and human exploration was added through a Joint Statement of Intent the previous year. T**he renewed agreement broadens the scope to space weather, robotic exploration and the sustainability of outer space activities.**



Credit: ESA

EU funds satellite connectivity for remote Greenland

On 7 September 2026, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen signed an agreement in Greenland to improve satellite internet connectivity in the remote regions of East and North Greenland. Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen and Greenland's Premier Jens-Frederik Nielsen were present at the signing. The EU will provide around €9.1M over five years, with co-financing from Denmark. Under the Enhanced Satellite Connectivity Project for Greenland**, led by national telecommunications provider Tusass, Eutelsat will provide OneWeb LEO connectivity to settlements and critical infrastructure.** According to Tusass, speeds in the affected areas will rise from 6 to 15 Mbps, and the service will provide a backup to the existing coastal radio relay network. The agreement is part of a €200M EU investment package for Greenland covering this year and the next.

IN OTHER NEWS

Italy confirmed as Chair of UN COPUOS

Italy has been confirmed as Chair of UN COPUOS for 2026–2027. Ambassador Mario Cospito, Special Commissioner of the Italian Space Agency (ASI), was appointed by consensus of the Committee's 110 Member States. He succeeds the former ASI President Teodoro Valente, who passed away in July.

Airbus and Unseenlabs to build France's CASSIOPÉE satellites

The French Directorate General of Armaments (DGA) has selected Airbus Defence and Space and Unseenlabs to develop CASSIOPÉE, France's next space-based signals intelligence system. It will succeed the CERES constellation and is expected to be operational by 2032.

Angola and Ghana join the Space4Ocean Alliance

Angola and Ghana have joined the Space4Ocean Alliance, signing during the International Space Summit in Paris on 9 September. The Alliance links space agencies with marine and maritime institutions and was launched in June 2025. With these signings, its African membership rises to six.

Open Cosmos joins UK TacSys framework

Open Cosmos has been selected as a supplier under TacSys, the UK Ministry of Defence's tactical communications framework worth up to £8B (€9.3B) and running until June 2034. It will provide satellite connectivity through its ConnectedCosmos LEO constellation.

Thales Alenia Space to build NigComSat-2A

Thales Alenia Space has signed a contract with Nigeria's state-owned NIGCOMSAT to build the NigComSat-2A geostationary telecommunications satellite. Based on the Spacebus platform, it will provide broadcasting, broadband and voice services from West and Central Africa to Southern Africa.

Space Norway appoints new Chair

Space Norway has appointed Bjørn Erik Reinseth, CEO of Oslo Science Park, as Chair of its Board. The appointment follows the departure of CEO Morten Tengs, with Rune Jensen serving as acting CEO.

Isar Aerospace reaches orbit and expands its launch manifest globally



Credit: Isar Aerospace

On 5 September 2026, **Isar Aerospace has reached orbit with the second flight of its Spectrum launch vehicle, the first European privately developed launcher to do so.** The "Onward and Upward" mission lifted off from the company's launch complex at Andøya Space in Norway and deployed its payloads, including CubeSats selected through the German Space Agency at DLR's Microlauncher Competition, into LEO.

In the same month, **Isar Aerospace signed a launch contract with Astroscale Japan** for the ADRAS-J2 active debris removal mission. The mission is part of JAXA's Commercial Removal of Debris Demonstration project and will fly on Spectrum from Andøya Space between 2027 and 2028. **On 14 September, Isar Aerospace and Maritime Launch Services also finalised the statement of work and programmatic milestones** for a dedicated Spectrum launch complex at Spaceport Nova Scotia, Canada. This meets a key condition of the ten-year, $112.5M facilities usage agreement signed in July 2026. Construction will continue towards a first orbital launch targeted for 2028. **Two days later, US-based SEOPS signed a multiple-launch service agreement with Isar Aerospace** for five dedicated Spectrum launches between 2028 and 2030 from Andøya Space and Spaceport Nova Scotia. The agreement nearly completes Isar Aerospace's 2028 launch manifest.

Loft Orbital and Marlan Space commit $1B to build AI satellite constellation

Loft Orbital and UAE-based Marlan Space have launched a $1B programme to build an Altair-Next Gen, an AI-enabled EO constellation. The programme expands the Altair constellation from ten to 50 satellites carrying radar, optical and other sensors. The satellites will be built in Abu Dhabi by Orbitworks, the joint venture Marlan Space and Loft Orbital established in 2024 and the first launch is planned for October 2026. Loft Orbital will provide the satellite platforms, onboard AI software and constellation operations, together with Mistral AI which will supply AI models running onboard the satellites for reasoning and natural-language tasking. BlackSky will contribute high-resolution optical satellites, and MaiaSpace has been selected as preferred launch provider once its services become commercially available.

ICEYE and Nokia partner to develop sovereign satellite communications systems

ICEYE and Nokia have formed a partnership to develop sovereign broadband LEO satellite communications systems for governments. The partnership extends ICEYE's sovereign mission model, under which client nations own and operate their own satellite systems, from SAR to satellite communications. The two Finnish companies will jointly integrate satellites, ground infrastructure and ruggedised user terminals, giving governments full ownership and control of each segment. The systems are intended to provide high-throughput, low-latency connectivity over priority areas for defence, border security, emergency services and disaster response. The first communications satellites are expected to launch in 2028.

Arianespace secures ten Ariane 6 launches at International Space Summit



Credit: Arianespace

During the International Space Summit in Paris, **Arianespace has signed seven agreements and three MoUs covering ten Ariane 64 launches**, marking the company's largest order intake since Ariane 6 entered service. On 9 September, **Amazon Leo ordered six additional Ariane 64 launches for its broadband constellation**, starting in 2029. This brings its total commitment with Arianespace from 18 to 24 missions by 2031. **On 10 September, Eutelsat contracted Arianespace for two dedicated Ariane 64 launches** in 2027 and 2028 to support the renewal of its OneWeb LEO constellation, for which 440 satellites are already procured and under construction.

The company also closed a deal with US satellite manufacturer AscendArc to launch KOREASAT 9, a high-throughput GEO satellite for South Korean operator HT SAT, launching on Ariane 6 to GTO in the second half of 2028. **The Exploration Company also signed an agreement with Arianespace to launch its Nyx reusable cargo capsule** for its first demonstration mission, under ESA's ALADDIN initiative. In addition to the launch contracts, Arianespace signed MoUs with three European companies - **ICEYE**, **EnduroSat** and **AgenaSpace** - to explore future launch and related-service opportunities on Ariane 6.

Eutelsat orders 229 more OneWeb satellites and expands LEO partnership

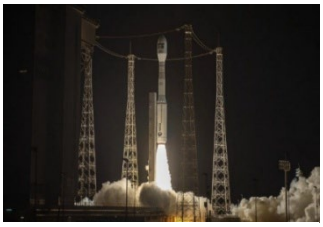
On 10 September 2026, **Eutelsat has signed an Authorisation to Proceed (ATP) with Airbus Defence and Space for 229 further OneWeb LEO satellites.** The ATP covers initial industrial activities, with the procurement estimated at €1B. The new satellites add to the 440 already ordered from Airbus, bringing the total to 669, with the first deliveries from the existing order expected next quarter.

The order came alongside a series of partnerships. On 9 September, **Eutelsat partnered with German company OroraTech** to host 48 thermal infrared wildfire-detection payloads on future OneWeb satellites, with an option for 48 more. The same day, **Eutelsat and French start-up Skynopy launched Global AKAR, a software-defined ground network combining Eutelsat's global ground infrastructure with Skynopy's orchestration technology to serve LEO operators**. The companies plan to deploy more than 100 antennas by 2029, cutting data latency to under three minutes and lifting throughput to 10 Gbps. Later in the month, **Eutelsat also completed its first OneWeb LEO rail connectivity trial in Poland,** and on 23 September, **it signed an agreement with Portuguese telecoms operator MEO to integrate OneWeb LEO into its fibre and 5G network and offer backup connectivity across the country.**

KONGSBERG partners with MDA Space and Telesat to expand Canadian presence

On 22 September 2026, **Norwegian technology group KONGSBERG has signed a MoU with MDA Space and a LoI with Telesat LEO ULC to expand its space and defence activities in Canada.** The agreements follow the bilateral agreement signed earlier this year between Canada and Norway. Under the MoU, the two companies will explore joint space and defence projects, with a focus on ISR over Arctic waters. The LOI covers assessing how the Telesat Lightspeed LEO satellite network could be integrated into KONGSBERG defence platforms, with the aim of giving military users in Norway, Canada and allied nations low-latency and secure military connectivity.

Avio flies second Vega-C mission and completes FD1 rocket demonstrator integration



Credit: Avio

On 15 September 2026**, Avio launched its second Vega-C flight of the year, deploying the Copernicus Sentinel-3C alongside ESA's FLEX mission**. Flight VV30 lifted off from Europe's Spaceport in French Guiana, with Avio acting as launch service operator for the second time. Vega-C first injected Sentinel-3C, while FLEX, an ESA Earth Explorer mission designed to map vegetation fluorescence and plant stress, was released about an hour later.

During the month, Avio also reported that it had completed integration of its FD1 flight demonstrator, a suborbital vehicle planned to launch from the Italian MoD Salto di Quirra test range in Sardinia, where commissioning of the temporary launch site is expected to conclude in November. On 29 September, **Avio USA broke ground on its approx. $500M solid rocket motor facility first in Hurt, Virginia**, which will supply US missile programmes, including for Lockheed Martin and Raytheon.

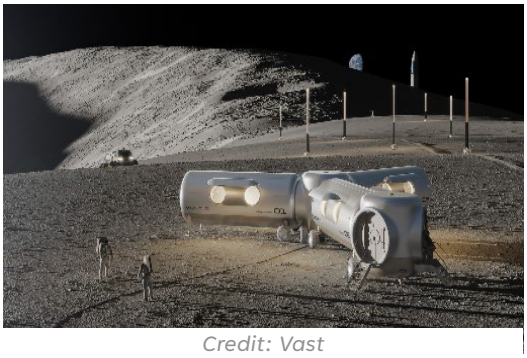
SpaceX's Starship reaches orbit for the first time and deploys 26 Starlink V3



Credit: SpaceX

On 28 September 2026, **SpaceX has reached orbit with Starship for the first time, deploying 26 Starlink V3 satellites during its 14th test flight.** One of the upper stage's six Raptor engines shut down early during ascent, but after assessing the vehicle's health, flight controllers cleared it to perform the single-engine burn needed to enter orbit, about 25 minutes after launch. Starship then deployed its payload, the first operational batch of Starlink V3 satellites, each designed to provide up to 1 Tbps of downlink capacity. Rather than complete the planned ten-hour, six-orbit profile, SpaceX ended the flight at its first scheduled checkpoint and brought the vehicle down in the Pacific Ocean north of Hawaii after about three hours.

Vast establishes Lunar Programs division to support NASA Moon Base plans



Credit: Vast

On 23 September 2026, **Vast established a Lunar Programs division to support NASA's plans for a permanently crewed Moon Base**. The division will apply the technologies and processes developed for the company's Haven-1 commercial space station, currently expected to launch in 2027, to lunar infrastructure. Vast plans to develop a lunar power station, a Haven-derived surface airlock and a multi-module habitat, alongside a communications and navigation satellite constellation for the lunar south pole. The architecture follows a three-phase approach aligned with NASA's iterative Moon Base plans.

IN OTHER NEWS

Exolaunch signs Starfall contract with SpaceX

Exolaunch has signed a contract with SpaceX to fly a Starfall mission on a Starship in 2029. The company will manage the end-to-end process of flying and returning experiments and payloads for pharmaceutical, biotechnology, materials-science, government, and research customers.

MaiaSpace wins its first long-term Asia customer deal

Japanese satellite manufacturer iQPS has tapped MaiaSpace to launch a range of SAR satellites starting in 2029. This is MaiaSpace's first long-term partnership with a customer from the Asia-Pacific region.

ICEYE signs Flood Insights deal with Sompo Japan

ICEYE signed a contract with Japanese insurer Sompo Japan to deploy the company's Flood Insights platform, aiming to speed up its response to flood events and better support customers affected by natural disasters.

4iG Group signs Starlink Mobile agreement with SpaceX

Hungarian telecommunications company 4iG has signed an agreement with SpaceX covering three initiatives: the current Starlink Mobile service, the future Starlink Mobile V2 service, and sovereign solutions for Europe to bring commercial satellite mobile connectivity to Hungary and Albania.

e-GEOS and iQPS partner on geospatial intelligence solutions

On 17 September 2026, iQPS and Italian company e-GEOS have launched a multi-year collaboration to develop geospatial intelligence solutions, supporting natural emergency management, mining activities and infrastructure monitoring.

Planet opens Berlin manufacturing facility for Pelican build-out

Planet opened its new Berlin manufacturing facility on 22 September 2026, marking the facility handover and cleanroom fit-out. The 5,700m^2 facility, announced last year to double Pelican satellite production capacity, is expected to begin production this fall.

The Exploration Company raises $450M as Nyx moves toward ISS Mission



Credit: The Exploration Company

The Exploration Company (TEC) closed a $450M Series C funding round co-led by Bessemer Venture Partners, Atomico, and Scaleup Europe Fund (EQT), marking the largest Series C funding round announced by a European space company. The company's roadmap prioritises the development of the Nyx reusable capsule and the Storm reusable rocket engine intended to power a future reusable super-heavy launcher. Nyx is designed to transport orbital cargo to current and future space stations and return it to Earth, with a target debut in 2028, before eventually scaling to crewed missions. Under the **ESA's ALADDIN (Autonomous LEO Accelerated Demo Docking to ISS Node) program, the company has secured a €760M contract** covering a demonstration mission to the ISS, where Nyx will dock with the space station before returning to Earth, with the mission expected to take place in the second quarter of 2029.

Open Cosmos secures €300M as it scales European satellite manufacturing

British space company raised €300M in a funding round led by Lightrock and ETF Partners, with participation from Institut Català de Finances, Entrepreneurs First and other international investors. The company plans to accelerate its satellite intelligence and connectivity services and to scale production across its four European manufacturing facilities in the UK, Spain, Portugal and Greece, targeting the capacity to produce up to one satellite per day. Open Cosmos has previously announced ConnectedCosmos, a LEO constellation designed to provide sovereign communications for businesses and government users. The announcement comes less than two weeks after Open Cosmos was selected as a provider for an **£8B (approx. €6.9B) framework** covering secure satellite communications from the UK government.

Rocket Lab advances Iridium Acquisition after stockholder approval

Rocket Lab is set to acquire Iridium Communications in a transaction valued at $54 per share, representing an enterprise value of $8 billion. By merging Rocket Lab's launch vehicle manufacturing with Iridium's operational LEO satellite network with L-Band spectrum, the transaction is set to expand Rocket Lab's capabilities across satellite communication and PNT services. The transaction is expected to close by mid-2027, subject to remaining regulatory approvals and other customary closing conditions.


Credit: Iridium

EnduroSat expands satellite production with $205M funding

Bulgarian EnduroSat is expanding its orbital infrastructure capabilities following a $205M financing round co-led by Riot Ventures and Atreides Management. The company plans to open a new manufacturing facility in the US and build a European space and defence hub. The expansion will support the standardisation and scaling of its satellite production, with the goal of also reducing data transmission costs. The company is expanding its customer base, including through **a recent contract with Vantor** to provide satellite buses for its Pulse fleet, a 24-satellite fleet, with deployment planned between 2027 and 2029.

Stoke Space raises $1B to advance reusable launch systems



Credit: Stoke Space

US launch company Stoke Space has raised $1B in a Series E financing round, bringing its total capital to $2.3B. Point72 Ventures and Spark Capital co-lead the round, which also includes new and existing investors. The funding will accelerate the development of the launcher Nova Pathfinder and expand the company's infrastructure. Nova is designed to be **fully reusable** across both stages. The rocket can carry several tons into orbit, and it's scheduled for a first launch in early 2027 from Cape Canaveral, Florida. Another milestone for the company is the development of **Nova Block 2**, a larger reusable rocket capable of delivering 15 metric tons to LEO, targeted to launch in 2029.

PLD Space extends Series C by €108M

PLD Space has extended its Series C to €288M with an additional €108M investment, bringing its aggregate funding to €488M. The transaction is led by Mitsubishi Electric Corporation, with COFIDES participating alongside new investors Endeavor Catalyst and MCH Private Equity. The new capital will support the industrialisation of MIURA 5 as the launcher moves towards commercial operations. PLD Space is preparing the vehicle's first orbital test **flight from the Guiana Space Centre in late 2026** and aims to increase its launch cadence to up to 30 missions per year by 2030.

Deep Blue Aerospace raises nearly €261M to accelerate Nebula rocket development

Chinese launch company Deep Blue Aerospace has closed two funding rounds totalling nearly ¥2B (approx. €261M), with major investors including Wuxi High-tech Zone Investment Holding Group, Yida Capital, Haisong Capital, and the Shanghai Free Trade Zone Fund. The funding will support the development of the company's Nebula reusable launch vehicles, as well as the development and production of its Thunder liquid engines. The program includes Nebula 1, designed to support small and medium satellite constellation deployments and a larger Nebula 2, which is designed to carry up to 25 tonnes to LEO and support large constellation deployments.

Varda raises $251M as it takes pharmaceutical research to orbit



Credit: Varda Space

Varda has recently closed a $251M Series D round, bringing its total funding to $598M. The round was led by Lux Capital and Natural Capital, with participation from other investors. The US space company plans to leverage orbital manufacturing to process pharmaceutical compounds in microgravity and scale its W-Series spacecraft for research in microgravity. Varda has already demonstrated its pharmaceutical processing capabilities on its W-1 and W-2 missions, laying the groundwork for commercial production.

Omnidea acquires Orbex assets to develop launch vehicle

Portuguese company Omnidea, which specialises in space-qualified subsystems, including propulsion technologies and launcher systems, **acquired several Orbex assets for an undisclosed value**. The assets include Orbex's launch vehicle manufacturing centre, a hub for flight and ground system electronics in Scotland, as well as the company's intellectual property. The deal does not include Orbex itself, its liabilities or debts, or the Sutherland Spaceport, marking another acquisition as the company expands its space operations.

IN OTHER NEWS

HiStarlink completes Series A2 financing

Chinese space company HiStarlink has completed a Series A2 financing round of more than ¥500M (approx. €65M) led jointly by Xiong'an Science and Technology Innovation Growth Equity Investment Fund and Wuhan Optics Valley Science and Technology Innovation Industry Investment Fund. The funding will support the development of its laser communication terminals.

HyImpulse extends Series A to accelerate launch operations

German launch company HyImpulse has extended its Series A with more than €50M in new funding led by JOIN Capital and Ace Capital Partners, bringing its total equity and public funding to over €125M, supporting the development of its launch activities.

HEO raises $25M to expand its imaging network into GEO

Australian space company HEO has raised $25M in a Series B round led by Beaten Zone Venture Partners. The new funding will support the expansion of its satellite imaging network into GEO.

Indian startup InspeCity raises $10.5M for satellite servicing

The space-tech company has secured $10.5M in Pre-Series A round led by Speciale Invest, Ashish Kacholia and other investors. The company develops technologies designed to extend satellite lifetimes and deorbiting operations.

Galaxia closes new funding round for satellite technology

Canadian space company Galaxia has closed a C$4.5M (approx. €2.8M) funding round co-led by Amiral Ventures and Invest Nova Scotia. The funding will accelerate the development and deployment of satellite systems with onboard computing capabilities for data processing in orbit.

Interlune secures $5M to build lunar infrastructure

US space company Interlune has raised $5M through a convertible SAFE from new and existing investors. The company, which initially focused on lunar resource extraction, is now expanding into technologies for lunar construction and other applications.

BRUSSELS CORNER



Commission President von der Leyen on European space policy

At the International Space Summit in Paris on 10 September, Commission President Ursula von der Leyen outlined Commission's space priorities: strengthening IRIS², developing a more competitive European space market, ensuring autonomous access to space, increasing the resilience of European space infrastructure and reinforcing European space governance. Space also featured in von der Leyen's State of the Union address on 16 September, space was included among the EU's strategic enablers for defence, alongside air and missile defence,

IRIS² moves towards implementation

In August, the European Commission and the SpaceRISE consortium signed an implementation agreement for IRIS². The agreement expanded the main constellation to 348 satellites. The first phase is scheduled for launch by the end of 2029.

European Commission announces work on European access to space

At the EU Access to Space Conference in Brussels on 23 September, Commissioner Andrius Kubilius announced an "Access to Space Tour" covering European launch sites, manufacturing and testing facilities. The initiative will feed into an Action Plan on European Access to Space, expected in 2027.

New security & defence developments

On 28 September, the Council adopted a Decision establishing the European Union Space Threat Response Architecture (STRA). The updated STRA sets out the EU mechanism and responsibilities for responding to threats affecting European space systems and services.

Also on 28 September, Council approved the SPACE project (multi-mission constellation, with common procurement) as one of the first five European Defence Projects of Common Interest under the European Defence Industry Programme (EDPI), envisioning participation from 20 countries - 18 EU member states, Norway, and Ukraine. The Council estimates major investment, up to EUR 24 billion in overall budget by 2034.

New Commission proposals relevant to the space sector

In September, the Commission presented two broader legislative proposals with implications for the space sector. The Public Procurement Act introduces provisions on security for critical infrastructure and supply chains, as well as a framework for European preference in public procurement. The European Innovation Act, presented as part of the Startup and Scaleup Strategy, explicitly covers space among its targeted sectors and introduces measures on R&D procurement and IP valorisation and protection.

LOOK AHEAD!



JAXA LAUNCHES MMX MISSION TO THE MOONS OF MARS

JAXA has scheduled the **launch of the Martian Moons eXploration (MMX) mission** for 20 October 2026 on an H3 rocket from the Tanegashima Space Center, with a reserve period running until 7 November. The mission aims to collect samples from Phobos, the larger of the two Martian moons, and return them to Earth in 2031. MMX also carries **Idefix**, a Franco-German rover developed by CNES and DLR, with NASA and ESA also participating in the mission.



ISRO PREPARES FIRST UNCREWED GAGANYAAN TEST FLIGHT

The Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) is preparing **Gaganyaan-1 (G1)**, the first uncrewed orbital test flight of India's human spaceflight programme, with launch targeted for the end of 2026. The flight will carry the half-humanoid robot Vyommitra to validate life-support and environmental control systems, alongside the performance of the human-rated launcher, re-entry and crew module recovery.



ESA HOLDS INTERIM MINISTERIAL MEETING IN ROME

On 15 December 2026, ESA Member States will meet in Rome for the **Intermediate Ministerial Meeting (IMM26)**, a gathering at ministerial level held between the regular Ministerial Councils. In June, **the ESA Council** stated that the meeting will give Member States an opportunity to define the European exploration roadmap for the coming years. Preparatory discussions have also covered launchers and Moon and Mars exploration.



PLD SPACE AND ROCKET LAB PREPARE MAIDEN LAUNCHES

PLD Space is targeting late December 2026 for the **inaugural flight of MIURA 5** from its launch complex at the Guiana Space Centre in French Guiana. Rocket Lab is also targeting late 2026 for the **maiden flight of Neutron**, its partially reusable medium-lift rocket, from NASA's Wallops Flight Facility in Virginia, Both maiden flight may slip into 2027.



ESPI HOLDS ITS ANNUAL CONFERENCE IN VIENNA

On 19–20 October 2026, ESPI will hold the **20th edition of its Annual Conference** at the Gartenpalais Liechtenstein in Vienna, under the theme *"Aspirations for a New Era"*. The conference will bring together decision-makers and leaders from across the global space community to discuss the geopolitical and strategic challenges shaping the sector.

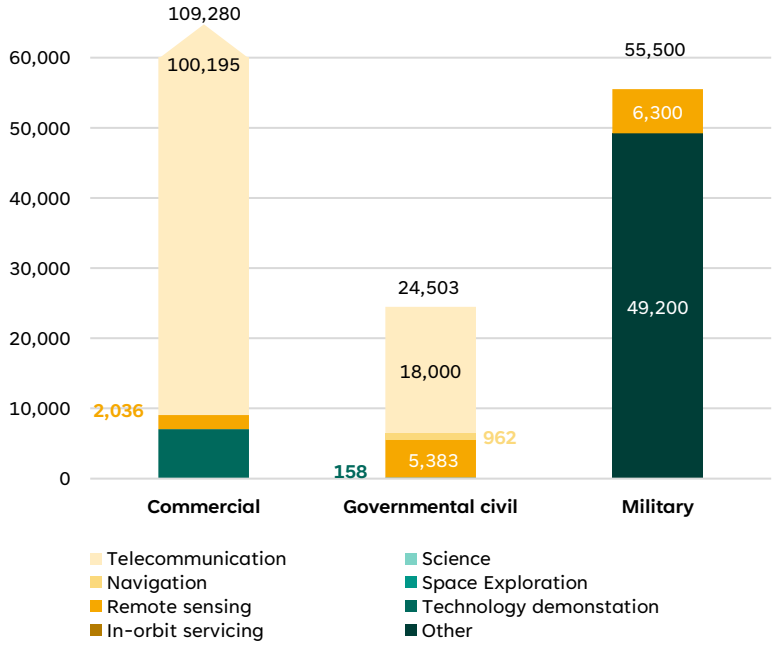
LAUNCHES & PAYLOAD – SEPTEMBER 2026

Launch provider's region	USA	China	Europe	Russia	India	Japan	New Zealand	Others	Total
Number of launches	8	10	2	2	1	0	4	0	**27**
Number of spacecraft launched	174	62	8	2	1	0	4	0	**251**
Mass launched (in t)	145	39	1.7	8.2	2.3	0	0.35	0	**196.5**

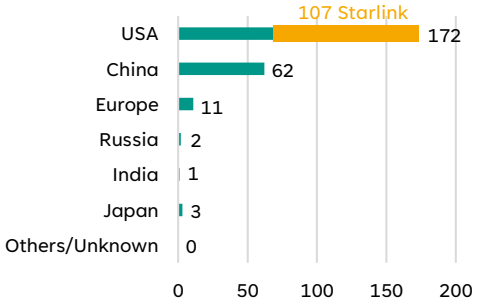
Top launch service providers of the month

1. SpaceX (8)
2. CASC (5)
3. Rocket Lab (4)

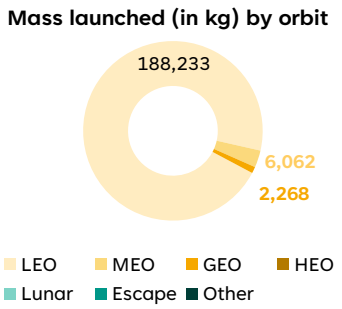
Mass launched (in kg) by market and by mission

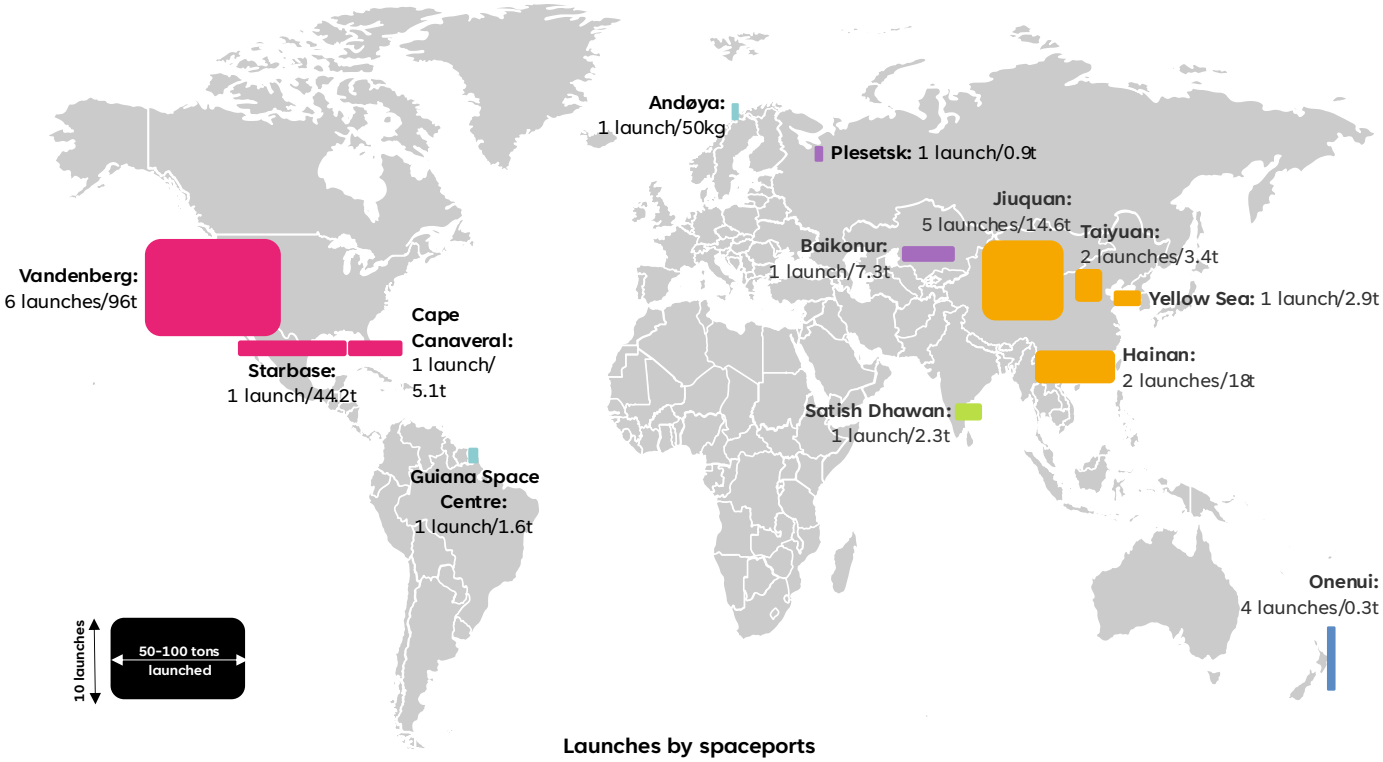


Number of spacecraft launched by payload owner's region



Mass launched (in kg) by orbit





Launches by spaceports

*The data is an estimation from ESPI's internal launches dataset, publicly accessible through the **ESPI Launch Dashboard**.*

ESPI Insights

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